



Appeal Decision

Site visit made on 4 August 2026

by K Reeves BA (Hons) MA MRTPI

an Inspector appointed by the Secretary of State

Decision date: 09 September 2026

Appeal Ref: 6007541

7 Vicarage Mansions, Queenstown Road, Wandsworth, London SW8 3RZ

- The appeal is made under Section 78 of the Town and Country Planning Act 1990 (as amended) against a refusal to grant planning permission.
 - The appeal is made by Mr Reeve against the decision of the Council of the London Borough of Wandsworth.
 - The application Ref is 2025/3183.
 - The development proposed is alterations including erection of a mansard extension to roof to form another level of accommodation.
-

Decision

1. The appeal is dismissed.

Main Issue

2. The main issue is whether the proposal would preserve or enhance the character or appearance of the Park Town Estate Conservation Area (CA) and preserve the setting of the Grade II listed Church of St Philip.

Reasons

Policy context

3. The appellant contends that the publication of the 2026 National Planning Policy Framework (Framework) materially alters the national approach to heritage and height and that, under Annex A, the development plan policies referenced on the Council's decision notice, namely Policies LP1, LP3, LP4 and LP5 of the Wandsworth Local Plan 2023 – 2038 (LP), should now attract very limited weight.
4. However, these policies remain broadly consistent with the Framework's requirements to conserve designated heritage assets, to secure high-quality design and to manage building heights through a plan-led spatial strategy. There is no substantive basis to regard them as materially inconsistent with national policy, and they therefore attract full weight in determining the appeal.

Designated heritage assets

5. The appeal site lies within the Park Town Estate CA, whose significance derives from its planned Victorian composition, classical terraces and the disciplined roofscape formed by shallow hipped roofs concealed behind parapets. The corner buildings around St Philip Square, including the appeal property, are integral to this composition. Their roof profiles, chimney stacks and proportions contribute directly to the area's historic character and to the coherence of the square.

6. The Grade II listed Church of St Philip stands opposite the site and forms the architectural focus of the square. Its tower and spirelet were designed to rise above the surrounding terraces, establishing a clear hierarchy between landmark and enclosure. The appeal building forms part of this setting, and its existing concealed roofline contributes to that intended relationship.
7. The proposal would involve the near total removal of the original roof and its replacement with a taller mansard structure. Even with the set back behind the parapet and the use of conservation rooflights, the increased height and altered profile would introduce a marked change in the established roof form. Although the dormers included in the previously rejected scheme have been removed, this change does not alter the fact that the increased height and altered roof profile would disrupt the disciplined roofscape of the corner buildings.
8. The appellant argues that the parapet conceals the proposal in close-range views and that only limited or distant glimpses would be possible. Visibility from the immediate public realm is restricted, but the roofscape's contribution to the CA's significance lies in its consistent form, height and massing across the corner buildings. The increased height would alter that established relationship, and the change in roof form would be appreciable in the context of the CA's overall composition even if public views are limited.
9. The increased height would also affect the setting of the Grade II listed church. The existing building sits visually below the church's tower, reinforcing the intended hierarchy between landmark and enclosure. The proposed mansard would raise the roofline and introduce a more assertive presence on the corner, reducing the clarity of that hierarchy. Seasonal tree cover provides partial screening, but the increased height would still diminish appreciation of the church's upper elements in views where the relationship between the two buildings is experienced.
10. The proposal would create a five-storey building. Policy LP4 of the LP defines such development as mid-rise and restricts mid-rise buildings to designated zones. The appeal site lies outside those zones, and the increased height would therefore breach the spatial strategy. While the appellant refers to the Framework's support for upward extensions, increased densities and taller forms at street corners, these provisions do not displace the development plan's locational approach to height.
11. The appellant refers to Policies L2 and L3 of the Framework, arguing that national policy encourages upward extensions, increased densities and taller forms at street corners. However, Policy L2(i) supports upward development only where it would not cause substantial harm to the character of a building or its surroundings. Here the increased height would disrupt the disciplined roofscape that contributes to the CA's significance and weaken the intended hierarchy between the appeal building and the listed church. Limited visibility from the closest street-level positions does not alter the underlying impact on the square's established composition or on the appreciation of the listed building's setting.
12. I have also had regard to the appellant's references to other mansard developments and to other appeal decisions, but those examples differ materially in their architectural context and do not alter my findings on the effect of the proposal on the CA or the listed building's setting.

13. Having regard to the above, the proposal would cause harm to the significance of the CA and the setting of the listed building. The Framework establishes that any harm to a designated heritage asset is a matter of considerable importance and weight, and requires that harm to be weighed against the public benefits of the proposal.
14. The appellant advances a range of benefits, including improved thermal performance, weathering, drainage and long-term durability, resolving historic water ingress, reducing pressure on the drainage system and providing additional naturally lit accommodation. However, the appellant has not demonstrated that the proposal is necessary to improve insulation, weathering or drainage. Further, the accommodation benefits are private in nature and do not amount to public benefits of meaningful scale.
15. The appellant suggests that glimpsed visibility should carry less weight than the benefits of additional floorspace, given the Framework's direction to give substantial weight to better use of underutilised buildings. However, substantial weight applies only where the criteria in Policy L2 of the Framework are met and where no conflict arises with the conservation of designated heritage assets. The proposal does not meet those criteria, and the Framework requires great weight to be given to heritage conservation irrespective of the degree of harm. The statutory duties under Sections 66 and 72 of the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990 reinforce this requirement.
16. When weighing the great weight to be given to the conservation of the designated heritage assets against the collective weight to be attributed to the benefits, the overall benefit would not be sufficient to outweigh the identified harm.
17. For these reasons, I conclude that the proposal would fail to preserve or enhance the character or appearance of the Park Town Estate CA and would also fail to preserve the setting of the Grade II listed church. It therefore conflicts with Policies LP1, LP3 and LP5 of the LP, which together require that development sustains and enhances the character and significance of heritage assets and responds positively to the established form and pattern of the area. The proposal also conflicts with Policy LP4 of the LP, which requires that mid-rise buildings are located only within the designated zones identified in the spatial strategy.

Conclusion

18. For the reasons given above, the proposal conflicts with the development plan and the material considerations do not indicate that the appeal should be decided other than in accordance with it. Accordingly, the appeal is dismissed.

K Reeves

INSPECTOR